



# Accessible Pedagogy Workshop II

## *Pedagogical Practice: Designing Access in Course Materials*

*“We can make pedagogy more accessible by recognizing ableism in our individual and institutional practices.”*

-Cheslea Jones<sup>1</sup>

## I. Universal Design for Learning

Has Universal Design become a buzzword? The concept was developed by American disabled architect & product designer Ronald Mace (1942-1998) to shape the design of all products to be aesthetic and usable to the greatest number of people, regardless of age, ability, or situation.

### **Seven principles of Universal Design (UD):**

1. Equitable Use
2. Flexibility in Use
3. Simple and Intuitive
4. Perceptible Information
5. Tolerance for Error
6. Low Physical Effort
7. Size and Space for Approach and Use

1990s: researchers at the Center for Applied Special Technology (CAST), non-profit based in Massachusetts adopted UD to shift from “individual” problem to “curriculum” inflexibility, extending UD principles to education through three main areas:

### **Universal Design for Learning (UDL):**

1. Multiple means of representation (the *what* of learning, or how content is presented)
2. Multiple means of action & expression (the *how* of learning, or how students show what they know)
3. Multiple means of engagement (the *why* of learning, or how students are motivated)

*Note: Workshop III will go into more detail on these concepts*

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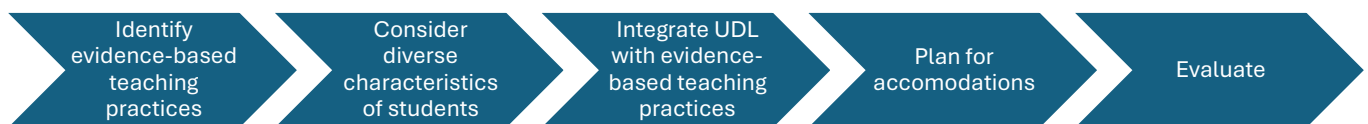
<sup>1</sup> Cheslea Jones, “Accessibility must be more than an add-on to online pedagogy,” *University Affairs* (21 August 2018): <https://universityaffairs.ca/opinion/accessibility-must-be-more-than-an-add-on-to-online-pedagogy/>

UDL philosophy grows from UD's architectural roots, advocating the use of multiple and flexible strategies to address the needs of *all* students—not just disabled and neurodiverse students—and empower them to have agency over their own learning.

For educators, UDL provides guidelines to set clear goals, anticipate learning barriers, create meaningful options, and embrace/encourage variability. Additional benefits:

- Flexibility to respond to changing space and technology (er...GenAI, anyone?) with planning, rather than with panic and reduction.
- Advocates social justice by emphasizing the importance of including everyone in discussions and creating space for varied perspectives
- Encourages student learning to drive design of syllabus, rather than a “one-size-fits-all” curriculum, offering multiple ways for students to show what they know and share their ideas/interpretations of course materials (e.g. Unessay Competition)

### Applying UDL to a Course:<sup>2</sup>



### Limitations of UDL:

- “Universal” does not address the importance of individual needs, personalized support, nor emphasis on wholeness (per 10 Principles of Disability Justice), and risks erasing embodied differences. **Accessibility does not equal Inclusivity**
- Institutional guidelines for assessment or degree completion clashes with flexibility (e.g. time for grade submissions)
- Lack of intersectionality (e.g. Indigenous/queer/disabled/autistic) can lead to oversimplification of course design and/or assessment
- UDL measures not implemented across unit/department/faculty, leading to student challenges and frustrations of learning from different professors
- Flexibility and choice can accelerate student anxiety and/or procrastination
- Instructor might not have training or knowledge to offer multiple aspects of accommodation for student learning
- Demands on instructor time and resources, often with insufficient institutional support (e.g. time for course preparation)

### *Are there other limitations?*

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<sup>2</sup> Adopted from Sheryl E. Burgstahler, *Creating Inclusive Learning Opportunities in Higher Education: A Universal Design Toolkit* (Harvard Education Press, 2020), 113.

*“In the neoliberal university, Universal Design may become a way of promising everything while not doing much of anything. I am no longer going to allow Universal Design to make me promises it doesn’t intend to keep.”*

-Jay Dolmage<sup>3</sup>

## II. Accessible Pedagogy

**A proactive, inclusive approach combining UDL and Disability Justice principles to create responsive educational experiences by removing physical, digital, and cognitive barriers to ensure all learners engage with course materials, while also honouring instructor labour.**

Course materials designed *with accessibility in mind* to meet needs of *most* learners, with room for adaptation and changes in Instructors & student needs. Centers equity-oriented frameworks and can include:

1. **Proactive design:** materials accessible from the start (e.g. PowerPoint slides posted, video transcripts provided) with adaptations for individual students (Handout: Access Needs)
2. **Flexible assessment:** offer choice (or option of choice) for students to demonstrate knowledge through multi-modal assessment. Assignments designed to achieve learning outcomes and Instructor explains the goal(s) of the assignments and expectations (Handout: Learning Outcomes). “Hard” & “Soft” deadlines offered (and explained!) for structure and to meet instructor labour.
3. **Inclusivity:** fosters an environment where students feel valued and respected as *adult* learners, recognizing varied disabled, neurodiverse, and intersectional experiences (e.g. chronic pain / menstrual or pelvic pain), including of illness and stress/anxiety, without the need for documentation. **We believe our students.**
4. **Interdependence:** syllabus clearly outlines course expectations and pedagogical goals (e.g. including number of pages to be read; Handout: Sample Syllabus), which provides mutual benefits: for students, equitable access to learning and reduced stigma; for instructors, quality materials and sustainable workload

Courses designed with accessibility can reduce the need for specialized accommodations by *already* offering choice and flexibility to meet diverse learning outcomes in a course. Additionally, this adheres to higher education principles of good practice, modified to incorporate aspects of UDL.<sup>4</sup>

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<sup>3</sup> Jay Timothy Dolmage, *Academic Ableism: Disability and Higher Education* (University of Michigan Press, 2017), 139.

<sup>4</sup> Arthur W. Chickering and Zelda F. Gamson, “Seven Principles for Good Practice in Undergraduate Education,” *American Association of Higher Education* (March 1987): 3-7.

## Designing Access into Good Practice<sup>5</sup>

| Principles of Good Practice                | Adjusting for Accessible Pedagogy                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clear communication with students          | Add statement in syllabus to meet with instructor, having specific office hours for assignment feedback, Access Needs                                   |
| Reciprocity and cooperation among students | Assign group work and encourage multiple ways for students to interact with each other; provide class time for group work; shared doc for student notes |
| Encourage active learning                  | Provide multiple ways for students to participate: notecards, presentation, emails, shared doc, shared app file, etc.                                   |
| Give prompt feedback                       | Regularly assess student progress and adjust instruction accordingly; explain Instructor hours and schedule limitations                                 |
| Emphasize time on task                     | Flexible deadlines, split exam, no late penalties but strict cut-off for assignments (without previous arrangement)                                     |
| Communicate high expectations              | Keep expectations high but minimize ableist language, provide accommodations to benefit diverse learners                                                |
| Respect diverse ways of learning           | Adopt assessment practices that reflect high expectations and learning outcomes by offering students alternatives (e.g. Unessay)                        |

<sup>5</sup> Table adapted and modified from Burgstahler, *Creating Inclusive Learning Opportunities*, 116.

### III. The Instructor's Dilemma: Time!

Instructor well-being is essential for the quality of student learning and sustainable teaching practices. Excessive workloads, expectations, and teaching frustration tend to lower job satisfaction and lead to increased stress, and burnout.

Designing accessible pedagogy *must* factor in instructor labour and accommodations.

#### Strategies for Course Design

##### 1. Humanize Yourself

Show ways for students to relate to you and to collectively create a learning experience centered on care.

- Share your background
- Add a welcoming slide for the first class or on Brightspace
- Have a more informal tone in syllabus

##### 2. Be Honest

Share the same grace and empathy you extend to students for your self.

- Apologize when late with grading or need to adjust a class & explain why
- Give yourself a self-evaluation: Why are you overwhelmed? (workload? Emotional labour? Doing too much? Writing deadlines? Personal stuff?)
- Invite guest lecturers (TAs, faculty colleagues) to take a break from course prep and also provide students with different perspectives

##### 3. Streamline Course Content

The materials and assessments incorporated into a course must achieve specific learning outcomes, rather than being overstuffed to cover all possible topics.

- Outline in syllabus the key questions students will investigate through the semester and explain how it ties with the learning outcomes
- Include varied activities to teach course materials (e.g. material culture study, library visit, guest lecture, “interview style”)
- Create a rubric for clarifying expectations and streamlining your grading.

##### 4. Set Boundaries

I know, this is perhaps the hardest part of being an academic. Nonetheless, we must learn to set boundaries both in our labour, availability, and schedule.

- Include in syllabus your availability and expectation of email responses
- Add a FAQ for term assignments to reduce the number of queries
- Block off time in your schedule for course prep and grading – and stick to it!

##### 5. Plus-One Approach

Apply *one* modification or adaptation of your course materials each time rather than doing a complete overhaul.